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Sisters at Sea

EVENT

A VALENTINE'S GETAWAY FOR
Solo Cruisers Who Love to Cruise!

VIRGIN VOYAGES
Resilient Lady

FROM MIAMI
FEBRUARY 14-21, 2027

ADULTS ONLY
18+
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Let's SAIL TOGETHER!

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- PROGRESO, MEXICO
- THE BEACH CLUB AT BIMINI (VIRGIN'S PRIVATE PARADISE!)

SOLO PRICING:

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- Award-winning dining INCLUDED
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Come solo, leave with sisters!

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BOOKING INFO:
MAULSBY TRAVEL CO.
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Sisters at Sea — A Valentine's Getaway for Solo Cruisers · Virgin
Voyages Resilient Lady · PortMiami · February 14–21, 2027 · Hosted by
Maulsby Travel Co.

A Voyage Pack from **In the Wake**
Hosted by **Tina Maulsby · Maulsby Travel Co.**

Welcome

This pack exists to make one specific cruise easier to plan: **Sisters at Sea — A Valentine's Getaway for Solo Cruisers Who Love to Cruise**, sailing **Saturday February 14 – Saturday February 21, 2027** on **Resilient Lady** out of **PortMiami**. It pulls together the ship-specific tips, port-specific advice, packing notes, group-cruise rhythm, and solo-women-aware practical content that you'd otherwise have to assemble from a dozen browser tabs over the months between booking and embarkation.

The pack is calm by design. There is no urgency, no upsell, no countdown. You can read it once and put it away, or use it as a working document over the year between booking and sailing.

If you're sailing solo for the first time, you are not the only woman in this group doing so. There is a real authority on solo cruising on this site — **Tina Maulsby** — and her **solo cruising stories** are worth reading before you sail. Tina is also your group host, so the rhythm of this trip will reflect her sensibility: practical, warm, low-pressure, and built around the simple promise *come solo, leave with sisters*.



Tina Maulsby — your group host

The site that produced this pack is independent. We don't take cruise-line affiliate commissions. We don't sell shore-excursion bookings. We don't run display ads. The full posture lives in the **affiliate disclosure**. Your purchase of this pack — separate from the cruise booking, which is handled by **Maulsby Travel Co.** — is the funding model that keeps this site free of advertising. If you'd rather not pay for the pack, the **support page** lists other ways to keep the site independent. Both are optional.

Includes an offline-capable Emergency Contacts section — fillable family handoff card, cruise-line and embassy numbers tailored to this itinerary, available offline after first load via **In the Wake's** PWA. Designed to share with one trusted person ashore before sailing.

At a Glance

Group name	Sisters at Sea — A Valentine's Getaway for Solo Cruisers Who Love to Cruise
Group host	Tina Maulsby, Maulsby Travel Co.
Group host contact	tina@maulsbytravel.com · 910-528-5077 · maulsbytravel.com
Ship	Resilient Lady
Cruise line	Virgin Voyages
Class	Lady Class — third of four (delivered 8 December 2022)
Departure port	PortMiami, Florida
Embark date	Saturday, February 14, 2027
Disembark date	Saturday, February 21, 2027
Itinerary length	7 nights / 8 days
Itinerary type	Western Caribbean + Bahamas (adults-only Valentine's sailing)

Audience	Women solo cruisers, 18+
Group focus	Valentine's-themed; community-first; "come solo, leave with sisters"
Group activities	Hosted meetups, Valentine's-themed welcome programming, group dinners (details from Tina)

What's structurally different about Virgin Voyages pricing

This is the headline difference between Virgin Voyages and the legacy lines (NCL, Royal Caribbean, Carnival): **Virgin bundles most of what the others charge for separately into the fare.** Built into your fare:

- **All restaurants** — over 20 included sit-down restaurants, cafés, and grab-and-go venues. No cover charges. Not a buffet — actual chef-led restaurants.
- **Basic Wi-Fi** — included in every cabin category. Premium streaming/video tier is an upgrade.
- **Soft drinks, still and sparkling water, non-pressed juices, and group fitness classes** — included.

A 2026 change to know about — gratuities. Until **October 7, 2025**, gratuities were folded into the Virgin fare and there was nothing added to your shipboard account at the end of the cruise. On that date Virgin moved to a three-tier fare model that shows gratuities as a separate line item — **\$20 per Sailor per night if pre-purchased before sailing, \$22 per Sailor per night if settled on your onboard account. Bookings made under the prior Legacy Fare structure (typically before Oct 7, 2025) keep gratuities included.** Because Sisters at Sea is a group booking handled by Tina, the right move is to **ask her directly whether your specific booking is Legacy Fare (gratuities included) or post-Oct-2025 fare (gratuities billed separately at \$20–22/night).** A 7-night sailing at the new rate adds \$140–154 per Sailor — material to your budget, and we work both scenarios through in **Section 5 — Budget Breakdown.**

What's **NOT** included regardless of fare type: alcohol (beer/wine/cocktails), specialty coffee at Grounds Club, premium fitness classes, spa treatments, shore excursions, the Squid Ink tattoo studio, the optional brunch drink package at The Wake, and anything labeled as a supplement.

The math feels different from a NCL or Royal cruise because of this. We work it through in detail in **Section 5 — Budget Breakdown**.

Ports of call

A representative sequence based on the group flyer. The exact day-by-day order varies by sailing — confirm yours with Tina or in the Voyages app:

1. **PortMiami, Florida** — embark Sat Feb 14 (afternoon)
 2. **Sea day** — Sun Feb 15
 3. **Freeport (Grand Bahama), Bahamas** — see </ports/freeport.html>
 4. **Sea day** — Tue Feb 17
 5. **Progreso, Mexico** (gateway to Mérida and Chichén Itzá) — see </ports/progreso.html>
 6. **Sea day** — Thu Feb 19
 7. **The Beach Club at Bimini, Bahamas** — Virgin Voyages' private beach club; see </ports/bimini.html>
 8. **PortMiami, Florida** — disembark Sat Feb 21 (morning)
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Section 1 — Your Ship: Resilient Lady

A Lady Class ship with a well-traveled history

Resilient Lady is the third of Virgin Voyages' four **Lady Class** ships, delivered by Fincantieri at Sestri Ponente in Genoa on 8 December 2022. By your February 2027 sailing she'll be just over four years old — well past the new-ship teething phase, with her crew rhythms settled and her venues in steady operation.

Her hull is identical to her sisters Scarlet Lady, Valiant Lady, and Brilliant Lady: 110,000 GT, 912 ft long, 2,770 guests at double occupancy (2,860 maximum), and a crew of 1,160. What sets Resilient Lady apart is her travels — she was Virgin's inaugural Greek Isles ship (May 2023), the first Virgin Voyages vessel ever to reach

Australia (Sydney, December 2023), and she has since sailed Mediterranean, Puerto Rico, and Caribbean rotations. As of the 2025–26 / 2026 spring season she is homeported at PortMiami running 7-night Western Caribbean + Bimini Beach Club round-trips. Your sailing falls within that deployment. For broader context on Virgin's Caribbean positioning alongside the legacy lines, **Caribbean Cruise Trends 2026** covers the deployment shifts.

What makes Virgin Voyages structurally different

Virgin Voyages is not a cruise line that has been retrofitted for adults. It was designed adult-from-the-keel:

- **Strictly 18+** — every guest must be 18 or older at the time of sailing. There are no children's clubs, no kids' menus, no waterslides, no family staterooms. The buffet that's normally the loud center of a mass-market ship doesn't exist on Resilient Lady at all.
- **No traditional main dining room.** Instead, **20+ restaurants and cafés are included in your fare**, with no cover charges. The Wake (steakhouse + raw bar with tableside martini service), Pink Agave (contemporary Mexican, fully gluten-free menu, the widest tequila and mezcal selection at sea), Extra Virgin (Italian trattoria), Gunbae (Korean BBQ at round social tables with soju), Razzle Dazzle (vegetable-forward), The Test Kitchen (chef's experimental tasting menu), The Galley (food-hall-style with multiple counters — this is NOT a buffet), The Pizza Place (Neapolitan-style, made to order), Sun Club Café (poolside Mediterranean), Lick Me Till Ice Cream (yes, that's the real name), Grounds Club (specialty coffee), Ship Eats (24-hour in-cabin, no room-service charge), and more.
- **No formal nights.** Smart casual for evenings. Some guests dress up for Scarlet Night (the fleet-wide red party held once per voyage). Nothing requires a tuxedo or a long gown.
- **Adult entertainment culture.** The Manor (two-story nightclub designed with House of Yes), the Red Room (Virgin's transformable theatre running in-house immersive productions like *Persephone*, *Booked!*, *Duel Reality*, *Scarlet Night*), Drag Brunch, and the Squid Ink tattoo studio (the first at sea). Virgin's onboard ethos is festival-meets-boutique-hotel rather than family-cruise-resort.
- **Ample balcony cabins.** 86% of Resilient Lady's 1,408 cabins have a balcony (Virgin calls them "Sea Terrace"); 93% are at minimum oceanview. Even her

Insider cabins are designed with natural-feeling materials and a hammock-style bed.

For solo women travelers — particularly those weary of legacy-cruise-line conventions — this combination tends to either click immediately or feel completely foreign. Most Sisters at Sea sailors find it clicks.

Resilient Lady is mid-sized for a modern cruise ship — 110,000 GT, ~2,770 sailors at full capacity. The **Ship Size Atlas** compares her side-by-side with Royal Caribbean and NCL ships, useful if you've sailed legacy lines and want a feel for the scale shift before you board. You can also follow her live position throughout your sailing in the **Ship Logbook**, which is a small but real comfort if family ashore wants to know where you are.

The cabin question for a solo woman

Before you commit, run the stateroom sanity check — a four-question filter that catches the bookings most likely to leave a cruiser unhappy. Solo women in particular benefit from the noise and motion questions in the filter.

Virgin offers three cabin categories on this sailing. Three quick reads:

- **Insider:** the windowless interior cabin. Resilient Lady's Insiders are nicer than equivalent interiors on legacy ships — they feel less like a closet — but you are paying for a windowless room. Choose this if budget is the deciding factor or if you're confident you'll be in the cabin only to sleep.
- **Sea View:** an oceanview window cabin. The window matters. Daylight in your cabin in the morning, ocean horizon when you're getting ready, the world feels different. The jump from Insider buys real value.
- **Sea Terrace:** a private balcony cabin. The flyer differential is unusually small — only modestly above Sea View on this group rate. **At that differential the Sea Terrace is the obvious choice if budget allows.** Virgin's Sea Terrace cabins are particularly nice: a small private outdoor space with a hammock-style chair, a place to drink your coffee at 6 AM watching the ship's wake, a way to step outside without dressing up. For a Valentine's-themed solo trip with sea days for reading and reflecting, the balcony is more than amenity — it changes the texture of the week.

If you're choosing on the margin, ask Tina what's still in the group block. The Sea Terrace cabins fill first and the differential here is small enough that they may be gone closer to sailing.

Before you commit to a specific cabin number, walk through accessibility, motion, noise, and view considerations against your booked deck and category — the things that don't show up in the deck plan. The **cabin organization article** covers the cross-line basics; for Virgin-specific layouts, the deck plans on Virgin Voyages' own site are the source of truth.

Dining as the social architecture

Because there is no main dining room with assigned seats, **dining is how you find your people on Resilient Lady**. The 20+ restaurants are organized as proper restaurants (book a time, walk in, sit, eat, leave when you're done). You can book ahead through the Voyages app once you board (some sailors book on Day 1 for the whole week). You can also walk in — most venues hold a portion of seating for walk-ups.

For a solo woman in a hosted group, this is good news: you're not stuck at a fixed table for eight strangers every night for a week. You decide each evening — tonight you eat with the group at Pink Agave, tomorrow you eat alone at The Pizza Place with a book, the next night you join a smaller group of new sisters at Gunbae and stay for hours at the round table.

Dietary needs. Pink Agave's full menu is gluten-free; The Galley has multiple stations including dedicated vegan and vegetarian options; allergies are taken seriously and the kitchen prepares severe-allergy meals separately when notified. We work this through in **Section 8 — Practical Logistics**.

Drinks on Resilient Lady

This is where Virgin Voyages charges separately. Beer, wine, cocktails, and specialty coffee are pay-as-you-go. Virgin doesn't sell a single all-you-can-drink package the way NCL and Royal do; instead, sailors load a "Bar Tab" at booking (often with a promotional bonus — buy \$300 in Bar Tab, receive \$50 extra; promotions vary). Bar Tab works at every bar onboard.

For a 7-night sailing, sailors who drink moderately (2–4 drinks per day) typically spend \$150–\$300 on drinks. Sailors who don’t drink alcohol can ignore the Bar Tab entirely — soft drinks, still and sparkling water, juice, and tea are included. For the math on whether a Bar Tab promotional load is worth it for your actual drinking patterns, the **drink calculator** on this site applies (the underlying logic translates to Bar Tab). The companion article **Is the drink package worth it?** walks through the breakeven math with worked examples — note that on Virgin specifically, the “package” question is really the “Bar Tab promotional load” question.

A note for women in recovery. Virgin’s adults-only adult-bar-everywhere atmosphere is occasionally framed as a “drinking cruise.” It doesn’t have to be. Plenty of Sisters at Sea participants will not be drinking. Grounds Club specialty coffee, the gym, Pink Agave’s mocktail list, and the wellness programming (yoga, meditation, group fitness) all run independently of the bar scene. There is no expectation that you drink, and no judgment from crew or fellow sailors if you don’t.

Connectivity at sea

Virgin Voyages includes basic Wi-Fi in every cabin category — speeds suitable for messaging family, checking email, and light browsing. The premium upgrade (sufficient for video calling and streaming) is paid. See the full **internet at sea guide** for the technical details, including how to avoid cellular roaming charges in port.

For most solo cruisers in the group, the right approach is:

- Use the included Wi-Fi for messaging family
 - Don’t try to stream video at sea
 - Use port-day cellular when possible (turn airplane mode off only at confirmed ports)
 - Keep one trusted person ashore informed via a daily one-line message; see **Section 6 — Emergency Contacts**
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Section 2 — Day by Day

A representative sequence. Order may differ for your specific sailing — confirm with Tina or in the Voyages app.

Day 1 — Saturday, Feb 14 — Embarkation, PortMiami (Valentine's Day)

Check-in window opens late morning. Virgin opens online check-in 45 days before sailing through the Voyages app. Pick the earliest available check-in slot that matches your travel — most groups embark in the noon–2 PM window.

The realistic timeline:

- **11:30 AM–1:00 PM:** First-wave check-in at Terminal V (Virgin's PortMiami home). Drop bags with porter at curb (TIP \$1–2/bag in cash), proceed through security and check-in, then up the gangway. Virgin's terminal is purpose-built and the flow is materially smoother than the legacy lines' terminals next door.
- **1:00–2:00 PM:** Cabins typically NOT ready until 2 PM. Drop carry-on with the bell desk or carry it. Head to The Galley or Sun Club Café for a relaxed lunch. The Galley feels less like an embarkation buffet zone and more like a casual food hall.
- **2:00 PM:** Cabins open. Find your cabin. Ask your stateroom host (Virgin doesn't call them attendants) about the Voyages app — your cabin tablet runs the app and is how you'll book restaurants, see the schedule, and order in-cabin dining.
- **2:30–4:00 PM:** Light exploration. Don't try to see everything. Find the **main pool deck**, one quiet bar, and your nearest elevator bank.
- **3:00 PM:** Mandatory muster drill. Virgin handles this through the app and an in-person check-in at your assigned station — about 10 minutes total.
- **4:30–5:00 PM:** Sailaway. Best viewing from the upper aft pool deck or Richard's Rooftop area (the latter is paid-suite-only) — failing that, the upper open deck near the running track.
- **6:00 PM onward:** Dinner. **Tonight will be heavy on Valentine's-themed welcome programming if Virgin runs any** (don't fabricate; check the Voyages app for actual scheduled events on the day). Tina's hosted group will likely have an opening-night gathering — check her communications.

For Day 1 carry-on: swimsuit, sunscreen, sunglasses, change of clothes, **all medications + 3-day buffer**, a layer (the ship is air-conditioned), passport (preferred over passport card + birth certificate — see Section 8), phone charger, refillable water bottle, embarkation paperwork, the Voyages app pre-loaded on your phone. Checked bags may not arrive until 7–9 PM.

Sailor Band: Virgin issues a wristband (or a card on request) at check-in that's your cabin key, payment method, and ID for the week. Most sailors prefer the band — it's waterproof, hard to lose, and you can wear it in the pool.

The Day 1 mistake to avoid: don't start the cruise by drinking at sailaway and then drinking through dinner and the welcome event. The first sea day is more enjoyable hydrated. There's a whole week.

For first-time cruisers in the group: see </first-cruise.html> for broader orientation; the embarkation rhythm in this pack is calibrated for Virgin specifically but the underlying patterns apply. If Virgin doesn't end up being your line for future sailings, the **Cruise Line Quiz** is the right starting point and the **Ship Quiz** walks the broader line-up.

Day 2 — Sunday, Feb 15 — Sea Day

This is the day you find your rhythm. For a hosted group cruise, it's also typically when Tina runs the **first hosted meet-and-greet** — check her group communications for time and location.

Morning: Coffee. Resilient Lady has good coffee at Grounds Club (paid specialty) and standard included coffee at The Galley and Sun Club Café. The Galley does a quiet breakfast with smaller crowds than the upper-deck venues.

Mid-morning to lunch — pick ONE bigger experience:

- **The Athletic Club** — Resilient Lady's running track and outdoor sport zone (boxing ring, basketball, climbing nets); morning is the cooler time for this on a Caribbean sailing
- **A spa visit** — sea-day mornings are when introductory rates appear. The Redemption Spa has a thermal suite with steam, sauna, salt room, and heated stone loungers; the day pass is a fair value, the upsold facials less so

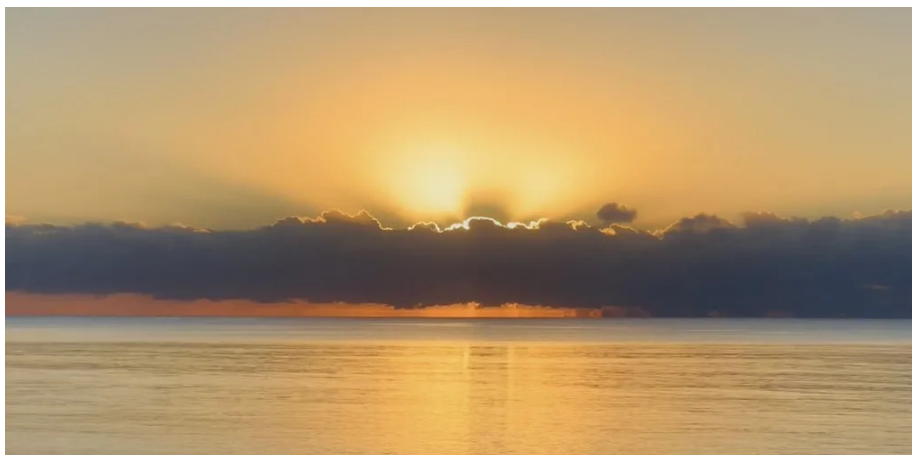
- **Pink Agave's lunch** — Mexican without the Cancún-chain feel; their gluten-free Caesar with grilled prawns is a standout
- **The Manor for “Brunch” if scheduled** — check the Voyages app the night before; some sailings run a Drag Brunch with bottomless mimosas (paid supplement) that sailors who go tend to recommend

Afternoon: Most of the group cruise's character happens here.

- The **first hosted meet-and-greet** is probably this afternoon — a casual gathering in a designated bar or lounge, with Tina present, where Sisters introduce themselves. The “come alone, leave with sisters” pattern starts here.
- The pool deck (the main pool is on Deck 15, with Sun Club Bar adjacent)
- A Red Room show in the evening — Resilient Lady's theatre carries Virgin's in-house productions (immersive, not Broadway-replica)

For solo women in the group: Pace yourself on Day 2. The first meet-and-greet is enough social work for one day. Don't feel obligated to stay for trivia, the show, AND The Manor at midnight. Choose two of the three. See **Tina's Solo Cruiser's Companion** for her expanded thinking on this.

Day 3 — Monday, Feb 16 — Freeport (Grand Bahama)



Sunset over the Bahamian sea, Grand Bahama coast

Arrival: Approximately 8:00 AM. Depart 5:00 PM. Freeport is on the south side of Grand Bahama. The cruise port is **Lucayan Harbour**, several miles from Port Lucaya (the main visitor area).

What Freeport actually is. Grand Bahama is beautiful but is still rebuilding from Hurricane Dorian (2019). Some Freeport blocks are still patchy years on. The cruise-port experience is fine, the beaches are excellent, and Port Lucaya Marketplace is walkable and pleasant — but Freeport doesn't have the polish of Nassau. Manage expectations and you'll have a great day.

For each of this week's port days, the **Port Day Planner** builds an hour-by-hour timeline from your priorities — useful when juggling taxi-ride windows, Sister meet-ups, and ship-back times. You can also pre-log each port to your **Port Logbook** before sailing, which gives you a place to compare the day you actually live against the day you planned.

Easy-day option: Stay at the cruise terminal. There's a small beach, vendors, and bar service. Spend a few hours, return to the ship for lunch, and use the afternoon for sea-day-style activities.

Half-day option: Port Lucaya Marketplace — about 10 minutes by taxi (\$10–15 for up to 4 passengers; some cruise lines run a complimentary shuttle on port days, confirm with Virgin). Open-air shopping, restaurants, beach access at Taino Beach nearby. Easy to spend a half-day comfortably.

Full-day option: Gold Rock Beach in Lucayan National Park — about 30 minutes by taxi (~\$40–50 round trip including wait time, agreed in advance). One of the prettiest beaches in the Bahamas: white sand, turquoise water, low crowds outside of cruise-day peaks. Pack water and snacks; food options at Gold Rock are limited.

For solo women: Freeport is a low-stress port for a solo day. Taxi drivers are licensed (queued at the cruise terminal with set zone fares; confirm fare before getting in). USD is universal. Most Sisters in the group will probably day-trip to Port Lucaya or Gold Rock — easy to find a buddy at breakfast and share a taxi.

For accessibility: The cruise terminal is wheelchair-accessible. Taxis on Grand Bahama are spacious enough for folding wheelchairs; accessible vehicles can be requested in advance through the terminal information desk. Port Lucaya is mostly flat with sidewalks; some areas have uneven surfaces. Gold Rock Beach has soft sand — beach wheelchairs may not be available, confirm in advance.

Weather on Feb 16. Freeport in February is peak Bahamas dry season — 70–80°F days, low 60s°F evenings, trade-wind cooled, minimal rain risk (the wet stretch is May–Oct). Mornings are crisp enough that the terminal beach feels cool before 10 AM, so the early-tender Sisters want a light cover-up. Water temperature ~72°F — refreshing if you swim, brisk if you linger.

Pack for Freeport: swimsuit, towel (Virgin provides), reef-safe sunscreen (the Bahamas appreciates it), sun hat, light cover-up, **\$60–80 USD cash** in \$5s and \$10s for taxi + tips + drinks, refillable water bottle.

Day 4 — Tuesday, Feb 17 — Sea Day

Your second sea day. By now you know the ship and you know some of the Sisters.

Suggestions you may not have considered:

- **The Test Kitchen for an early lunch** — Virgin’s chef-driven tasting venue. The lunch service is shorter and quieter than dinner; a good way to experience the kitchen without committing to the full evening
- **Wine tasting** at Sip Lounge if scheduled — sea-day afternoons are typical
- **A Manor dance class** — some sailings run dance lessons at The Manor in the afternoons (salsa, swing); fun and friendly for Sisters who might attend solo
- **The Sun Club Café for a long, slow lunch** — the menu is Mediterranean and the wraparound view is the best inexpensive seat on the ship
- **Reading on your Sea Terrace balcony** if you booked one — the second sea day is when the value of that balcony becomes obvious

Group rhythm: Tina may schedule a **second hosted event** today — a more substantive activity than the meet-and-greet. Possible formats: a group dinner at one of the included restaurants (often Pink Agave or Extra Virgin for groups), a hosted onboard activity (a Manor dance class, a Drag Brunch), or a quieter lounge gathering. Check her communications.

Scarlet Night. Virgin’s signature once-per-voyage red party usually happens on a sea day or the night before disembarkation. Bring one red item — even just a red top or a red lipstick. The party runs across multiple decks and the energy is festive without being overwhelming. Check the Voyages app for which night it falls on.

Day 5 — Wednesday, Feb 18 — Progreso (Mexico)



Market stalls along the Progreso malecón, Yucatán

Arrival: Approximately 8:00 AM. Depart 5:00 PM. Progreso is a small Mexican fishing town on the north coast of the Yucatán Peninsula, but the cruise port is what makes it interesting: a **6.5-kilometer pier** — the world's longest — that reaches past the shallow Gulf waters to bring cruise ships in. A free tram runs between the ship and the pier-end terminal (about 10 minutes each way).

Why Progreso is on the itinerary. Progreso itself is modest. The port exists because of what's *inland*: **Chichén Itzá** (one of the New Seven Wonders of the World, ~2.5 hours by bus), **Mérida** (a colonial-Spanish capital with ornate Paseo de Montejo mansions and a working cathedral on the central plaza, ~45 minutes), the **cenotes** (underground swimming caves), and the **Chicxulub crater** (the asteroid impact site that ended the dinosaurs). For a Caribbean cruise port, this is one of the most culturally rich shore-day options in the western hemisphere.

Easy-day option: Stay at the pier-end terminal area or take the tram into Progreso town. The malecón has calm Gulf waters, cheap seafood restaurants (fresh ceviche \$8–15, cold cervezas), and a small-town Mexican atmosphere. Beach clubs rent chairs and umbrellas for \$10–15. Not a destination beach, but authentic and unhurried.

Full-day option (the cultural one): Chichén Itzá — a long day. Ship excursions run \$100–150/person; independent tours (booked in advance with reputable Yucatán operators) run \$60–90. Plan: ~2.5 hours each way by bus, plus 2–3 hours at the site. You'll be tired by ship-time but you've seen one of the great human achievements of the Americas.

Full-day option (the city one): Mérida — about 45 minutes inland by bus or shared van (~\$15–20 each way independently; ship excursions \$50–80 with guided commentary). Spanish colonial architecture, the Plaza Grande, the Casa de Montejo, Mérida's Cathedral, and excellent local lunch (cochinita pibil at Casa de los Frailes is a regional standout). Easy to do as a half-day if you take the early tour and come back for ship lunch.

Half-day option (the swimming one): A cenote tour — most cenotes are 30–60 minutes from Progreso. Dzibilchaltún is the closest of the well-known cenotes and includes a Maya archaeological site (ship excursions ~\$70–90).

For solo women: Progreso is friendly to solo travelers but the language gap matters. If your Spanish is limited, an organized tour (ship-booked or a reputable independent operator) is the saner choice for Chichén Itzá or Mérida. Other Sisters in the group are likely doing the same — pair up at breakfast.

For accessibility: The pier tram is wheelchair-accessible. The terminal at the end of the pier has air-conditioned waiting areas, restrooms, and shops. Chichén Itzá has uneven stone paths and the climb to El Castillo is no longer permitted — accessibility is mixed. Mérida's historic center is partially accessible but cobblestone streets are challenging. Confirm specifics with the tour operator before booking.

Pack for Progreso: if doing Chichén Itzá or Mérida — closed-toe walking shoes, sun hat, reef-safe sunscreen (Mexico legally requires it on beaches and at cenotes), refillable water bottle, **\$60–100 USD cash** (USD widely accepted; pesos available at ATMs onboard or at the pier; small bills best). If doing only the malecón — swimsuit, water shoes, \$40–60 cash, otherwise the same.

Day 6 — Thursday, Feb 19 — Sea Day

Your third sea day. Use it.

By Day 6 most of the Sisters have settled into their rhythm. Some are double-booked across the day; some have found a quiet corner and are reading. Both are valid.

This is also a good day for **the things you've been deferring**: the spa treatment you said you'd think about, the lunch with the Sister you keep meaning to talk to longer, the show in the Red Room you missed earlier in the week. Tina may run a final pre-disembarkation gathering today or tomorrow morning.

For solo women specifically: Day 6 is often when the trip's emotional arc shows up. You came alone; you are no longer alone in any practical sense. You'll be home in two days. Sit with that for an hour somewhere quiet — the Sun Club Café in late afternoon is a good place. The point isn't melancholy; the point is noticing the trip has done something worth noticing.

Day 7 — Friday, Feb 20 — The Beach Club at Bimini (Bahamas)



A pink cottage on the Bimini shoreline, Bahamas

Arrival: Approximately 9:00 AM. Depart 6:00 PM. **The Beach Club at Bimini is Virgin Voyages' designed-and-operated beach destination on North Bimini**, in the Bahamas, just 50 miles from Miami. It sits **within the broader Resorts World Bimini complex** (Virgin doesn't own the land — Resorts World does) but Virgin designed the

Beach Club and runs it as a Virgin-exclusive on the days Virgin ships are in port. On Virgin-free days the property opens to Resorts World guests and other day-pass visitors; when *Resilient Lady* is at the pier, the Beach Club is yours for the day.

On the Beach Club specifically. Beach Club days are as good as cruise-line private destinations get. Virgin designed the Beach Club specifically for the adult sailor: less of the kids-on-inflatables atmosphere of Castaway Cay or CocoCay, more of a beach-resort-day vibe with included cocktails (or Bar Tab cocktails, depending on what you've loaded), a DJ in the afternoon, and several pools and beach areas to spread out across.

Free with your cruise fare:

- Beach access (multiple beach areas; the main beach is broad and shaded near the back)
- Lunch buffet at the Beach Club (yes, there's a buffet here even though there isn't one onboard — different operational logic for a beach day)
- Lounge chairs (first-come; arrive in the early tender wave for shaded ones)
- Pool access (multiple pools)
- Tram service around the property
- Restrooms and shower facilities

Paid (extra cost, decide ahead):

- **Cabanas** — premium beach spaces with day-bed seating, fan, and dedicated server; ~\$200–500/day depending on category and demand
- **Premium drinks** if not on Bar Tab
- **Optional excursions** — snorkel tours, boat charters

For solo women: Bimini is an easy port for the group to spread out and regroup. The Sisters often do an informal lunch together at the Beach Club around noon — natural meeting point without needing to organize. The DJ-driven afternoon energy is friendly and group-positive without being a meat-market.

For accessibility: The Beach Club tender process is accessible (Virgin uses tenders specifically configured for accessibility). The Beach Club itself is mostly flat with paved pathways; beach wheelchairs are typically available. Some pool deck areas have steps; ask at the welcome desk.

Weather on Feb 20. Bimini in February runs 70–78°F daytime, mid-60s°F evenings — peak Bahamas dry season, brief showers very unlikely (the wet stretch is Jun–Oct). The Gulf Stream-cooled trade wind makes the morning beach cool until ~10 AM, so the early-tender wave wants a wrap until the sun climbs. Water temperature ~72–74°F — refreshing for a swim, brisk if you linger.

Pack for the Beach Club: swimsuit (worn aboard or in your bag), reef-safe sunscreen, sun hat, sunglasses, **\$20–40 USD cash** for tipping (gratuity is included, but \$5 to a server who took good care of you for the afternoon goes a long way), phone in waterproof pouch is reasonable; see **the tech guide**.

Day 8 — Saturday, Feb 21 — Disembarkation, PortMiami

The realistic timeline:

- **6:00–8:00 AM:** Breakfast available at The Galley and Sun Club Café. Eat now if your bag is in the hall already.
- **7:30 AM:** Customs clearance complete. Self-disembarkation begins for sailors carrying their own bags.
- **8:00–10:00 AM:** Color-coded groups called for assisted disembarkation. Your color and time will be in the Voyages app the night before.
- **8:30–10:30 AM:** Most sailors off. PortMiami customs is efficient — expect 15–30 minutes.
- **By 11:00 AM:** Ship empty.

The night before: Pack carefully. Set out clothes for the morning, your toiletries, phone charger, and one outfit for travel. Everything else goes in checked bags by the pickup time Virgin specifies (usually 11 PM). Bags get tagged with your color and dropped in the hallway. They'll be sorted by color at the cruise terminal.

Tipping at the end of the cruise. Whether you're on Legacy Fare (gratuities included) or post-Oct-2025 fare (gratuities billed as a separate line at \$20–22/Sailor/night), the structural gratuity is paid by the time you disembark — no end-of-cruise envelope is required either way. **However**, additional cash tips for outstanding service are appreciated:

- Stateroom host who went above and beyond: \$20–40 cash in an envelope, end of cruise

- A specific bartender who remembered your preference all week: \$10–20 cash on the last visit
- A specialty restaurant server who made a meal memorable: \$10–15 cash at the meal
- Your cabin steward's daily turn-down notes deserve nothing extra unless service was exceptional

These are *bonuses on top of the structural gratuity*, not the obligatory end-of-cruise envelope of legacy lines.

If you're staying in Florida a night or two:

- Uber/Lyft from PortMiami to Miami International (MIA): ~\$20–35, 20–30 minutes
- Uber/Lyft to Fort Lauderdale-Hollywood (FLL): ~\$50–70, 45–60 minutes
- South Beach is 15 minutes from PortMiami; an extra night there extends the warmth of the trip by a day

Killing time before an evening flight. PortMiami terminals do not store bags — TSA prohibits cruise-terminal bag storage. Two workable options:

- **Third-party luggage storage** via Radical Storage or Bounce, \$5–8/bag/day at host locations in Brickell and downtown (10-min Uber from the port).
- **Hotel day-room** at a Brickell or downtown hotel, ~\$60–90 if booked direct.

What pairs well with a slow Sisters-at-Sea morning if you're not flying out until evening:

- **Brunch in Brickell or Coconut Grove** (10–15 min Uber): the unhurried way to extend the trip's pace by a few hours.
- **Vizcaya Museum & Gardens** (15-min Uber, ~\$25): quiet, photogenic, sit-on-a-bench appropriate.
- **South Beach** (15-min Uber): Lummus Park walk, Ocean Drive, change-of-shirt in your day-bag.
- **Bayside Marketplace** (close to port, walkable): touristy but a workable lunch + harbor-view fill.

MIA without an Uber. Honest answer for a Sisters-at-Sea group with luggage: **don't fight it — Uber/Lyft, \$20–30, 25 minutes.** Metromover + Metrorail technically works but transferring bags between three systems is not the way you want this trip to end.

Airport-arrival timing. For a domestic flight after 5 PM, leave the port by 2 PM. For an international flight after 7 PM, leave by 3 PM. MIA TSA lines run 30–60 min during the Saturday-afternoon cruise rush.

Group goodbye: Tina will likely organize a final group goodbye — possibly the night before disembarkation in a lounge, possibly in the Voyages app group chat at the terminal in the morning. Stay for it if you can; the friendships formed on a Sisters at Sea cruise are real.

Section 3 — Pre-Cruise Countdown

Booking 12+ months out gives you a substantial planning runway. The site's / **countdown.html** tool breaks this down day-by-day; what follows is calibrated for *this* cruise specifically.

12+ months before — booking and group setup

- **Confirm group booking with Tina** at tina@maulsbytravel.com / 910-528-5077
- Decide on cabin category (Insider / Sea View / Sea Terrace) — see Section 1 for trade-offs
- Pay deposit (Virgin Voyages group bookings typically require a deposit at booking; balance due ~120 days before sailing — confirm with Tina)
- Get/renew passport. Allow 6–10 weeks for new passport processing; longer for first-time
- Buy travel insurance if you want it. **Strongly recommended for a 7-night Caribbean trip.** Your auto-insurance and home-insurance providers are usually NOT the right source; specialist providers (Allianz, Travelex, Travel Guard) are

8 months before — soft logistics

- Plan your travel to PortMiami. Most sailors fly into Miami International (MIA) or Fort Lauderdale-Hollywood (FLL); the Voyages app surfaces transfer options once you're booked
- Book pre-cruise hotel if flying in early (Friday night before, Feb 13, recommended — Saturday morning embarkation gives buffer for flight delays)
- Apply for/renew TSA PreCheck or Global Entry if relevant
- Begin medication-supply coordination if you take complex daily medications — for an 8-day trip you want at minimum a 14-day supply on hand, in original prescription bottles, in your carry-on

6 months before — final commitments

- Final payment to Virgin Voyages via Tina (typically 120 days before sailing — confirm exact date)
- Confirm dietary requirements with Virgin Voyages (works through the Voyages app and your booking; Tina can assist)
- Pre-print or save digital copies of: passport, Virgin boarding pass once available, any insurance details, group-cruise welcome materials Tina sends

3 months before — final prep window

- Online check-in opens 45 days before sailing in the Voyages app, but get your passport details and travel documents loaded as soon as the app permits
- Order anything you need from Amazon (don't wait until the last week). The **In the Wake cabin organization article** and **tech & photography guide** have specific item recommendations
- Get any prescription refills filled (full week + buffer). Your pharmacy may need 2–3 weeks lead time for vacation overrides
- Notify your bank/credit card about international travel: Bahamas, Mexico (February 14–21, 2027)

30 days before — packing window

- Start the packing list (next section)
- Plan your Scarlet Night red item (a red top, a red dress, a red lipstick — anything red counts)
- Confirm flight status, transportation to PortMiami
- Check the weather forecast for Florida and the Caribbean — February is dry season; storms unlikely but possible
- Charge all electronics; verify power-bank capacity is within TSA limits

14 days before — soft logistics

- Print or save digitally any documents you want as backup
- Confirm you have the Voyages app installed and your booking linked
- Confirm Tina's group communications are reaching you (check spam if not)

2 days before — arrival prep

- Confirm flight status
- Pack
- Set out passport + cruise documents in one place
- Eat a relaxed dinner; sleep early

Day before — Florida arrival

- Arrive Friday Feb 13 if flying
 - Check into pre-cruise hotel
 - Group meet-up sometimes happens at the pre-cruise hotel — check Tina's communications
 - Eat a relaxed dinner; sleep early
 - The Virgin Voyages terminal at PortMiami opens around 11 AM Saturday morning
-

Section 4 — Packing List (calibrated for THIS itinerary)

This list is tuned for: **tropical climate (February Caribbean — warm/humid days, mild evenings)**, **three port days** (one beach-and-pier day in Freeport, one inland-cultural day in Progreso, one beach-club day at Bimini), **Scarlet Night** (Virgin's once-per-voyage red party, no formal-wear required), and a **Valentine's-themed Virgin Voyages atmosphere** (smart casual evenings; Virgin's whole vibe leans dressy-but-not-dressed-up).

For broader packing context, see </packing-lists.html>.

Documents and money

- Passport (strongly preferred over passport card + birth certificate). Passport must be valid for at least 6 months past your return date; check now and renew if necessary
- Printed copy of cruise documents (and digital copies in the Voyages app)
- Travel insurance card and 24-hour emergency phone number (separate from main insurance card; in different bag)
- \$200–300 USD in small bills for tips, taxis, beach chairs, port-day cash purchases
- 2 credit cards (split between travelers / kept in different bags)
- Driver's license (separate from passport, in a different bag)

Carry-on (must arrive on the ship with you)

- All medications + 3-day buffer (NEVER in checked bags). Daily / scheduled / controlled-substance prescriptions all in original labeled bottles
- Phone, charger, headphones
- Swimsuit (cabins not ready until 2 PM; pool is open before that)
- Sunscreen and lip balm
- Layer / light cardigan (the ship is air-conditioned)
- Refillable water bottle

-
- 1 change of clothes
 - Small bag of snacks (granola bars, fruit) for the embarkation queue if it's slow
 - Reading material

For the ship — daytime

- 7 daily outfits (mix of casual: linen pants/dresses, light tops, shorts)
- Comfortable walking shoes (Resilient Lady is mid-sized; expect 2–4 miles of walking per day)
- 1 pair of pool sandals
- A light cover-up or kaftan for moving between pool and lunch
- A cardigan or light wrap for over-air-conditioned restaurants

For the ship — evening

- 5–6 evening outfits — Virgin is **smart casual**. Examples that work: a midi dress and sandals, dressy linen separates, a jumpsuit, dressy denim with a silk top. Examples that don't: shorts and a t-shirt for dinner at The Wake, athleisure in the Red Room, a full ball gown for dinner (you'll feel overdressed)
- 1 pair of dressier shoes (low heel, wedge, or cute flats — not stilettos; the ship's gentle motion makes high heels uncomfortable)
- **One red item for Scarlet Night** — a red dress, a red top, a red kimono, anything that reads red. Sailors take this seriously; the photos are real
- **One Valentine's-themed item for Day 1** if you want — pink or red, something special-feeling. Tina's group will lean into the Valentine's mood
- A small evening bag (a clutch or crossbody)

Beach gear (port days)

- Beach bag
- Quick-dry towel (Virgin provides full-size towels but lighter ones travel better)
- Water shoes (Bimini's beach is mostly sand but there are coral patches; Freeport beaches vary)

-
- Underwater camera or phone waterproof pouch (one IPX8-rated pouch for personal use — see **the tech guide** for a specific recommendation)
 - Cash in \$5s and \$10s for beach club tips and beverages

For Progreso specifically (if doing Chichén Itzá or Mérida)

- Closed-toe walking shoes (sneakers or sturdy sandals, NOT flip-flops)
- A light long-sleeve shirt for sun protection on the bus and at the ruins
- A scarf or shawl that can double as a head cover at religious or cultural sites
- More cash than your other port days (\$60–100 USD)

Solo-cruiser specific items

- A book or e-reader for solo dinners and quiet moments
- A small spiral notebook for writing down places to remember (port-day discoveries are easy to forget by Day 8)
- A lanyard or clip for your Sailor Band if you prefer the card option (cards have a habit of vanishing into pockets, especially late in the day)
- See **Tina's Solo Cruiser's Companion** for her complete solo-traveler recommendations

Optional but useful

- Magnetic hooks (4–6 — Resilient Lady's cabin walls are steel; this is a real lifehack — see **cabin organization**)
- Over-door organizer for the bathroom
- Reusable laundry bag
- Power bank (carry-on only)
- Foam earplugs (cabin-neighbor noise / hallway noise)
- Sleep mask (cabins have light leak from hallway)
- A small sewing kit or safety pins (Scarlet Night and Valentine's outfits sometimes need an emergency adjustment)

Skip

- Hairdryer (cabin has one)
 - Iron (banned by Virgin — fire safety)
 - Heating pad / electric kettle (banned)
 - Surge-protected power strips (banned — see **cabin organization** for the pre-approved alternatives)
 - More than 2 bottles of wine per adult (Virgin allows 2 sealed wine bottles per cabin in carry-on at embarkation; rest is held)
 - Drone (banned at sea and at Caribbean ports)
 - Heavy formal wear — no white-tie or black-tie nights on Virgin
 - Anything that says “kids” — there are no children on this ship
-

Section 5 — Budget Breakdown

All prices below are approximate and subject to change. Confirm specific numbers in the **Voyages app** once you have a booking, or with **Tina** for group-rate-specific items.

What's already included in your Virgin Voyages fare

This list is longer than the equivalent NCL or Royal Caribbean list, and the difference is real money:

- Cabin
- **All meals at all 20+ included restaurants and cafés** (with the exception of an optional brunch drink package at The Wake)
- **Basic Wi-Fi** in every cabin category (premium streaming/video tier is an upgrade)
- Soft drinks, still and sparkling water, non-pressed juices, and tea
- Group fitness classes (yoga, HIIT, indoor cycling, meditation)

- Most onboard entertainment (Red Room productions, The Manor nightclub, Drag Brunch unless ticketed, sea-day programming)
- Pool decks
- Athletic Club running track and outdoor sports zone
- The Beach Club at Bimini (lunch buffet, lounge chairs, beach access, pools)

Gratuities — depends on when your booking was contracted. Bookings under the Legacy Fare (typically before Oct 7, 2025) include gratuities in the fare and nothing is added at the end of the cruise. Bookings under the post-Oct-2025 fare tiers show gratuities separately at \$20/Sailor/night pre-purchased or \$22/night settled on your onboard account — that's **\$140–154 per Sailor for a 7-night sailing**. Confirm which fare type your booking falls under with Tina before you build the rest of the budget.

What's NOT included

Item	Approximate per-person cost (7 nights)
Bar Tab — moderate drinker (2–4 drinks/day)	\$150–\$300
Bar Tab — heavy drinker (5+ drinks/day)	\$350–\$600
Specialty coffee at Grounds Club (daily)	\$25–50
The Wake brunch drink package	\$30 (one-time)
Drag Brunch ticket (if ticketed that sailing)	\$30–60
Spa treatments	\$200–500 (one or two)
Shore excursions — Freeport	\$0 (terminal) to \$80 (Gold Rock + private taxi)
Shore excursions — Progreso (Chichén Itzá)	\$60–150
Shore excursions — Progreso (Mérida)	\$50–80
Shore excursions — Bimini Beach Club (cabana)	\$0 (free beach) to \$500 (premium cabana)
Squid Ink tattoo (if you decide to commit)	\$100–500+ depending on size
Premium fitness classes	\$25–40/class
Pre-cruise hotel (1 night Miami)	\$150–350
Airport-to-port transfer (round trip)	\$40–80

Item	Approximate per-person cost (7 nights)
Tipping above what's already included	\$30–80

A realistic mid-range solo budget (per person, 7 nights, on top of cruise fare)

For a Sea View cabin at the flyer rate, with a moderate Bar Tab and one or two excursions:

- Sea View cabin (group rate, approximate) — \$2,508
- Gratuities — **\$0 if Legacy Fare; \$140 if post-Oct-2025 fare pre-purchased; \$154 if billed onboard**
- Bar Tab (moderate) — \$250
- Specialty coffee here and there — \$30
- Shore excursions (Chichén Itzá or Mérida + Freeport beach taxi) — \$150
- Spa treatment (one) — \$250
- Pre-cruise hotel + transfer — \$250
- Cash for ports + bonus tips — \$150

Total beyond fare: ~\$1,080 (Legacy) or ~\$1,220–1,234 (new fare). So a \$2,508 Sea View becomes roughly \$3,588–\$3,742 at the door. A useful number to know up front.

For a similar trip on a comparable NCL or Royal sailing, the auto-gratuity (\$140), drink package (\$700+), specialty dining package (\$150+), and Wi-Fi (\$120+) alone add ~\$1,100 on top of fare *before* shore excursions and spa. Even with Virgin's gratuities unbundled, the door-total typically lands close to even with the legacy lines, which is partly why the line has the loyal following it does.

If your spending shape differs — Sea Terrace cabin, heavier Bar Tab, multiple spa days — drop your numbers into the **cruise-budget-calculator** and the door-total updates in seconds. The line-by-line comparison against NCL and Royal becomes much sharper when you swap your specifics in.

How to spend less

- Keep the Bar Tab moderate; mocktails, soft drinks, and water are included

-
- Independent shore excursions in Progreso (Mérida especially) instead of ship excursions
 - Skip the spa upsells; the thermal-suite day pass is the better value
 - Stay at the Beach Club's free amenities instead of booking a cabana
 - Skip Drag Brunch tickets if you'd rather see the Manor at night

How it costs more

- A Sea Terrace cabin instead of Sea View (already worth it at the flyer differential, but worth naming)
- A premium cabana at the Beach Club (\$300–500)
- Multiple spa treatments
- Heavy Bar Tab spending
- A Squid Ink tattoo (memorable; not impulse-priced)
- Multiple specialty premium experiences (private cabanas, premium fitness packages)

A note on cruise-line “value” framing

Virgin's marketing emphasizes how much is included. The framing is accurate — more so than NCL's “Free At Sea” or Royal's “perks” framings, which often mask costs. Virgin's pricing is straightforward in a way the legacy lines' isn't: the price is the price, plus your bar tab, plus your excursions, plus your spa (plus, on post-Oct-2025 fares, the unbundled gratuity). The surprises are smaller.

Section 6 — Emergency Contacts

If you're reading this in a crisis, the numbers below are the right calls in priority order. Skip to the bold State Department line below if you don't know where to start. If you're the cruiser preparing for the trip, fill in the handoff card and share it with one trusted person ashore before sailing. Numbers verified 2026-06-05 against Virgin

Voyages' own **Security Guide and Contact List PDF** and U.S. State Department sources; cruise-line numbers occasionally change with promotional cycles — confirm yours on your booking confirmation.

This page is part of In the Wake's offline-capable PWA. After your first visit, it works without Wi-Fi — even at sea, in port, or anywhere your family member loses signal.

The family handoff card

Fill in before sailing. Share with one trusted person ashore. Privacy note: passport number and date of birth are sensitive — share with someone you fully trust, and don't email this card unencrypted.

Cruiser's full legal name (as on passport): _____

Date of birth: _____

Passport number: _____

Cruiser's mobile (Wi-Fi calling at sea): _____

Cruise line: Virgin Voyages

Ship name: Resilient Lady

Sailing date: Saturday, February 14, 2027

Disembark date: Saturday, February 21, 2027

Booking / reservation number: _____

Stateroom / cabin number: _____

Travel insurance company: _____

Policy number: _____

24-hour assistance line: _____

Group host: Tina Maulsby, Maulsby Travel Co.

Group host contact: tina@maulsbytravel.com · 910-528-5077

Pre-cruise outbound flight (airline + flight number + date):

Pre-cruise return flight (airline + flight number + date):

Anything to share in a medical situation

(allergies, medications, conditions, advance directive on file):

Trusted contact at home (cruiser's records):

Name: _____ Phone: _____ Relationship: _____

Universal 24/7 line — the right call when in doubt

U.S. State Department, Overseas Citizens Services

- From the U.S. or Canada: **+1-888-407-4747**
- From abroad: **+1-202-501-4444**
- Available 24 hours a day, every day. They can locate the ship, contact the cruise line on the family's behalf, and coordinate consular services if the situation is in port.

This is the number Virgin Voyages itself directs families to in its own Security Guide. It applies regardless of cruise line.

Cruise-line numbers (Virgin Voyages)

The State Department line above is the right call for a true at-sea emergency. The Virgin Voyages contact paths below are useful for non-emergency communication (relaying a non-urgent message, billing or booking questions, pre-cruise rebooking).

A safety note on Virgin Voyages and ship-phone contact. Virgin Voyages' primary website **does not appear to publish a public ship-to-shore phone number** on its main FAQ pages (verified 2026-06-05). Virgin's own Security Guide directs families with at-sea emergencies to the U.S. State Department line above and to the FBI / U.S. Coast Guard for incidents involving U.S. nationals. The onboard ship-emergency dial code is **911** — which works *from a Virgin Voyages cabin tablet*, but is not a number families ashore can call from outside.

If you actually need to reach someone on the ship and the situation is non-emergency:

- **Sailor Services (the shoreside team):** Virgin Voyages' Sailor Services email is **sailorservices@virginvoyages.com**. Several third-party directories list a Sailor Services phone number, but because we cannot verify a specific number on virginvoyages.com itself (their site directs to a help portal contact form), **we recommend confirming the current Sailor Services phone number on your booking confirmation email or by asking Tina directly.**
- **Tina (your group host)** — she can call her Virgin Voyages group desk on your family's behalf during business hours: tina@maulsbytravel.com / 910-528-5077.
- **For port-day emergencies**, the ship's port agent name and direct number for each port appear in the Voyages app once you board. The port agent is a local Virgin contact at every stop.

This is the same posture this site takes for NCL and Royal Caribbean: we don't write a phone number we cannot verify against a primary cruise-line source, because a wrong number in an emergency is worse than no number.

U.S. embassies and consulates — this itinerary's ports

Verified against the U.S. Embassy / State Department directories and Virgin Voyages' own Security Guide (see source link at top of section).

- **Bahamas (U.S. Embassy, Nassau)** — covers Freeport (Grand Bahama) and The Beach Club at Bimini.
 - 24/7 emergency line: **+1-242-461-5025** (press option 1 for emergencies)
 - Main line (business hours): +1-242-322-1181
 - Address: 42 Queen Street, Nassau, New Providence
- **Mexico (U.S. Consulate General, Mérida)** — covers Progreso and the Yucatán Peninsula.
 - Phone: **+52-999-689-0660** from Mexico, or 011-52-999-689-0660 from the U.S.
 - The ship's port agent can also reach the consular agent quickly for cruise-port emergencies in Progreso.
- **Mexico — broader (U.S. Embassy, Mexico City)** — backup if Mérida is unreachable: +52-55-5080-2000.

What each authority will need from you

Have these ready before you call. It cuts panic-call confusion in half.

Calling the State Department: ship name (Resilient Lady), sailing date (Feb 14, 2027), full legal name of the person aboard, your name, your relationship to them, what you know about the situation.

Calling Virgin Voyages Sailor Services or Tina: booking number, ship name, sailing date, full legal name of the person aboard, cabin number if assigned, your name, your relationship.

Calling an embassy or consulate from a port: your full name (you the caller), passport number if you're abroad, where you are physically right now, what you need, whether anyone is hurt.

Decision tree — which call do I make?

- **Medical emergency at sea** → State Department first; they coordinate with the cruise line.

-
- **Missing person at sea** → State Department; the Cruise Vessel Security and Safety Act of 2010 requires the cruise line to log incidents and report to the FBI.
 - **Port-side emergency** → local emergency services first; embassy/consulate second; State Department third.
 - **Pre-cruise flight delay or rebooking** → Virgin Voyages Sailor Services (via the Voyages app or the email above) or Tina.
 - *Don't call 911 — it can't reach a ship in international waters.*
 - *Don't call the cruise line's general booking line — it routes to sales, not emergencies.*

Where to go next

- For the deeper systems explanation (how port agents work, what CVSSA 2010 requires of cruise lines, why ship-to-shore numbers vary by line), see **/reaching-someone-at-sea.html**.
 - For group-cruise coordination, contact **Tina Maulsby**.
-

Section 7 — Seasickness on a Caribbean Cruise

Seasickness is the question most cruisers ask before their first sailing and the topic most cruisers underplan for after. The Caribbean in February is generally calm — trade winds are steady, hurricane season is well past — but Resilient Lady is on open ocean for several days of this trip, and a 7-night sailing will produce some hours of swell that you'll feel.

The baseline

Most cruisers, on a February Caribbean itinerary on a Lady Class ship, will not get meaningfully seasick. Resilient Lady's stabilizers handle most ocean motion well. You'll feel the ship in a few situations:

- **Open-ocean sea days** when the route or weather puts the ship in chop

-
- **Tender approach at the Beach Club at Bimini** if the ship is anchored (Virgin sometimes uses tenders here depending on conditions) — the smaller tender boats feel motion more sharply than the main ship

If you don't usually get carsick or queasy in other moving environments, the odds you'll get meaningfully seasick on this cruise are low.

If you do get seasick — what works

Five options, in order of how often experienced cruisers actually use them:

1. **Look at the horizon.** Free, immediate, scientifically valid. Your inner ear and your eyes are sending mismatched signals; resolving the visual signal with a fixed reference point reduces the mismatch. Going outside is the most effective single thing you can do.
2. **Eat lightly when feeling rough.** Heavy meals + alcohol + ship motion is a worse combination than any individual factor. Skip a multi-course dinner on a rocking sea day; eat a banana, drink water, return to a real meal when conditions calm.
3. **Ginger candies or ginger tea.** Genuinely helpful for mild nausea; no side effects; safe with all medications. Pack a small tin in your day bag.
4. **Drug-free wristbands** (acupressure on the P6 wrist point). Some swear by them, others find them theater. Cheap to try; no harm if they don't work for you.
5. **Over-the-counter or prescription medication. Talk to your pharmacist or doctor about which fits your medical context** — we don't link product purchases here because the right answer depends on what else you take, not on what's convenient to buy. The FTC has been clear about not mixing health recommendations with affiliate revenue, and we agree.

Cabin choice and motion

If motion sensitivity is a real concern, the cabin matters:

- **Midship, lower deck** = least motion. On Resilient Lady, that's roughly Decks 7–9, sections 6–8.
- **Forward and aft cabins** feel more motion. Forward feels pitch (front-back); aft feels yaw (side-to-side) plus engine vibration.

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- **Higher decks** feel more roll than lower decks (further from the ship's center of gravity).

If you booked an Insider, you don't have horizon access from your cabin — which can intensify nausea if it does set in. If you're highly motion-sensitive, the upgrade from Insider to Sea View or Sea Terrace is worth it for the window alone.

Prevention timing

The pattern most experienced cruisers follow:

- **Night before boarding:** take an oral preventive even if you don't feel queasy yet. Medication is more effective preventively than as treatment.
- **First morning of the cruise:** repeat the dose if a 24-hour formulation isn't on board.
- **First sea day:** repeat once more if needed. By Day 3 most cruisers have adapted and need nothing further.

Skip preventive dosing if you're confident you don't get motion sick — the medication has costs (drowsiness, dryness) and shouldn't be taken if not needed.

What NOT to do

- Don't drink alcohol heavily on a rough sea day if you're feeling unwell. The combination is worse than either alone.
 - Don't read or stare at your phone in bed during pitching seas. Both create the visual-vestibular mismatch that triggers nausea.
 - Don't lie down in a windowless cabin if you can avoid it. Get to a window or deck.
 - Don't assume a balcony solves everything — some cruisers actually feel motion *more* on a balcony because of the rapid visual reference.
-

Section 8 — Practical Logistics

The everyday details that no one mentions until they bite. Skim this section once now and once again two weeks before sailing. The detail here is deliberately heavier than in the rest of the pack — these are the questions that, when unanswered, become real problems at the worst possible moments.

Travel documents

A current U.S. passport is the right document for this cruise. It is *technically* possible to sail this 7-night Caribbean closed-loop itinerary on a passport card or on a certified birth certificate plus state-issued photo ID under federal “closed-loop” rules — but this is the place where saving \$130 on a passport application becomes a multi-thousand-dollar problem if anything goes wrong.

Three real scenarios where the passport matters and the alternatives don’t:

If you experience a medical emergency at sea or in a foreign port and need to fly home from the closest international airport (Mérida, Nassau, Miami), only a passport will get you on the airplane. Birth certificates won’t fly. If you miss the ship at a port and need to catch up to it at the next stop, only a passport will let you fly. If your wallet is stolen in Progreso and you need an emergency travel document from the U.S. consulate in Mérida, the embassy works much faster when you have a paper copy of an existing passport rather than starting from scratch.

The technical rules for U.S. citizens, in order of practical importance:

- **Passport validity** must extend through your return date. Mexico has been lenient with the “six months past return” rule but enforcement varies; the Bahamas requires a passport valid for the duration of stay. Even when not strictly required, six months is the sane safety margin. If your passport expires within nine months of February 21, 2027, **renew now** — passport processing as of 2026 typically runs 4–8 weeks for routine, 2–3 weeks for expedited.
- **Name match must be exact.** The name on your passport must match your Virgin Voyages booking exactly — every character, every middle name, every hyphen, every suffix. Virgin’s automated systems will deny boarding for mismatch. If you legally changed your name since booking (marriage, divorce, gender

confirmation), contact Virgin Voyages via Tina the moment you have the legal paperwork. Updates take 2–4 weeks to propagate; don't leave it for the week before sailing.

- **REAL ID** applies to your domestic flight to Miami, not to the cruise. TSA began full REAL ID enforcement on **May 7, 2025**, so every domestic flight in the U.S. now requires REAL-ID-compliant identification at the TSA checkpoint. Look at your driver's license: if there's a star or a flag in the upper right corner, you're compliant. If not, your options are a REAL ID renewal (varies by state, often requires an in-person DMV visit), or use your passport for the flight.
- **Non-U.S. passport holders** need to check visa requirements for each port. U.S. citizens don't need visas for Bahamas or Mexico for cruise stops; many other passport holders do. Tina can connect you with documentation guidance, but get on this 6+ months out — visa processing can take weeks.

If you're applying for a first passport and the February date feels close, the U.S. State Department offers "expedited at agency" service in major cities (in-person, by appointment, \$60 surcharge). Call the State Department's National Passport Information Center at 877-487-2778 for current options.

Travel insurance

Strongly recommended for a 7-night Caribbean trip. Read this subsection slowly; the math is real.

Why your home insurance is not enough. U.S. health insurance — including Medicare and standard employer-sponsored plans — does not cover medical care outside U.S. waters. Onboard medical visits on Resilient Lady are not covered. Care at hospitals in Mexico or the Bahamas is not covered. Most importantly, **medical evacuation by helicopter or charter air ambulance** from international waters back to a U.S. hospital is not covered, and that's the line item that gets expensive: a sea-to-shore evacuation typically runs \$30,000–\$80,000; an international air-ambulance flight to a U.S. hospital can run \$150,000–\$300,000.

What good travel insurance covers, in priority order:

1. **Emergency medical evacuation** (the line item that bankrupts uninsured travelers): aim for at least \$250,000 coverage; \$500,000 is comfortable. This is non-negotiable for international cruise travel.

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2. **Medical care at sea or in port:** at least \$100,000 coverage; \$250,000+ is comfortable. This includes hospitalization, prescriptions, ambulance-on-land transport.
 3. **Trip cancellation:** reimburses your cruise fare, hotel, airfare if a covered reason prevents you from sailing. Standard “covered reasons” include illness (yours, a family member’s), severe weather, jury duty, employer-mandated work, terrorism at the destination, and a few others.
 4. **Trip interruption:** reimburses costs if you have to leave the cruise mid-sail (flight home, hotel, etc.). This is what saves you if you miss the ship at a port and have to fly to catch up.
 5. **Baggage delay / loss:** smaller dollar amounts but practical for delayed luggage.
 6. **24/7 emergency assistance hotline:** all reputable insurers include this. Call it for translator help, medical referrals, finding the U.S. consulate, etc.

The “Cancel for Any Reason” (CFAR) upgrade. Standard cancellation requires a covered reason. CFAR covers everything — cold feet, family pet emergency, work demands, you just changed your mind. CFAR typically reimburses 50–75% (not 100%), costs an additional 20–40% on top of the base premium, and **must usually be purchased within 14–21 days of your initial trip deposit**. If you’ve already passed that window, CFAR is no longer available for this trip.

Pre-existing conditions are the most-claimed exclusion. A “pre-existing condition” is anything you’ve been treated for, prescribed medication for, or sought medical advice about in the 60–180 days before purchasing the policy. Most insurers offer a **pre-existing condition waiver** that covers these, but it has a strict purchase deadline (usually within 14–21 days of initial trip deposit).

What to actually do.

- Buy travel insurance within two weeks of paying your cruise deposit. Don’t wait until 90 days out.
- Get the pre-existing condition waiver; it costs little and protects significantly.
- Add CFAR if your situation feels uncertain.
- Use a third-party insurer, not the cruise line’s bundled offer. Allianz Global Assistance, Travelex, Travel Guard, IMG, and World Nomads are the major reputable U.S.-market providers. Compare on InsureMyTrip or Squaremouth.

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- Keep the policy number, the 24/7 assistance line, and a one-page summary in your wallet alongside your passport.

Onboard money: the Virgin Voyages cashless system

Once you board, your **Sailor Band** (or, if you opted for the card alternative, your Sailor Card) replaces cash for everything onboard. The system is invisible until something goes wrong, and then it's worth understanding.

At check-in, you link a credit card to your stateroom account. Throughout the week, every Bar Tab purchase, every spa treatment, every premium fitness class, every Squid Ink commission, every shore excursion booked through the ship — all of it accumulates on your shipboard account. On disembarkation day, your linked card is charged for the total. Virgin emails the itemized statement in the morning; review it before leaving the ship.

If your booking falls under the Legacy Fare, gratuities are already in your fare and the end-of-cruise total is materially smaller than it would be on NCL or Royal — sometimes the only line items are Bar Tab and one excursion. For post-Oct-2025 bookings where gratuities are unbundled, the gratuity line (\$20/Sailor/night pre-purchased or \$22/night onboard) appears as a separate item, but the door-total is still typically lower than the legacy lines because everything else stays bundled.

Credit card vs debit card. Use a credit card if you have one. Virgin places a “hold” on the linked card during the cruise — typically 15–30% of expected total charges, refreshed daily. On a debit card, this hold reduces your available cash, sometimes for 3–7 business days *after* the cruise ends. With a credit card, the hold reduces available credit, not cash.

Foreign transaction fees. The card you link should not charge foreign transaction fees. Virgin Voyages' billing entity is U.S.-based for most charges, so your end-of-cruise charge processes as a U.S. transaction. Most modern travel cards have no foreign-transaction fees regardless. If you bring a card that charges 3% on foreign transactions, that 3% applies to your entire onboard bill.

Cash you'll actually need. The Sailor Band handles ~95% of onboard charges. The remaining 5% is cash, and on a Virgin sailing it's smaller than on legacy lines because gratuities are included:

- **Porters at the cruise terminal:** \$1–2 per bag, expected, in cash
- **Tipping in port** (taxi drivers, tour operators, beach club attendants in Freeport and Progreso): cash, in U.S. dollars, in \$5 and \$10 denominations
- **Bonus tips above what's already included:** \$5–10 in an envelope for a stateroom host or specialty server who went above and beyond — *optional and always appreciated*

A fair budget for cash on a 7-night Virgin cruise is **\$150–200 per person**, brought as \$5s and \$10s. Less than the legacy-line equivalent because gratuity is already paid.

Tipping etiquette on Virgin Voyages

This is the section most different from a NCL or Royal pack. Whether your booking is Legacy Fare (gratuities included) or post-Oct-2025 fare (gratuities billed at \$20–22/Sailor/night as a separate line), **the structural floor is paid by the time you disembark**. Cash tips on top are bonuses, not the obligatory end-of-cruise envelope.

The practical landscape:

Pre-cruise / embarkation tipping. Porters at the cruise terminal handle your luggage from curb to ship. They are expected to be tipped — this is not Virgin-included. The norm is \$1–2 per bag, in cash, handed at the curb. Underfunding this can result in your bag being “lost” or arriving very late.

Stateroom host at end of cruise. Many sailors add a cash tip to their stateroom host on top of the included gratuity, in an envelope at end of cruise. The norm on Virgin is **\$20–40 per cabin** for a 7-night, more if your host did something memorable.

Genuinely optional — Virgin's crew is well-compensated through the included gratuity. Don't tip out of guilt.

Bartenders. Tipping at Virgin bars: a 20% gratuity is automatically added to Bar Tab charges. Cash tipping above that (\$1 per drink for a bartender who knows your name and pour preference) is appreciated but not expected.

Specialty restaurant servers. Same logic — gratuity is built in. Adding \$10–15 cash for an exceptional server at a memorable meal is appreciated; for an ordinary meal, no extra is needed.

Tour operators in port. Virgin doesn't include port-tour gratuities. Independent shore excursion guides typically expect U.S. norms: \$5–10 per person for a half-day group tour, \$10–20 per person for a full-day, \$5–10 per person for the bus driver if separate.

Taxi drivers. 10–15% on the metered fare or agreed price; round up to the next dollar. In Mexico USD is widely accepted; in the Bahamas USD is standard.

Beach Club at Bimini staff. \$5–10 if a server took good care of you for the afternoon. Virgin's onboard gratuity covers Beach Club crew, but the cash bonus is appreciated.

The general principle: **extra is optional and always appreciated.** Virgin doesn't run on under-tipped crew — gratuity is structural. If you choose to add cash for memorable service, that's a true bonus. The **cruise-tipping calculator** totals what you'd spend on auto-gratuity-included sailings against your planned cash extras — a useful sanity check if you're comparing Virgin to NCL or Royal for a future trip. For the broader context of why cruise gratuities work the way they do across the major lines in 2026, **Cruise Tipping 2026** is the longer read.

Port-day safety and what to do if you miss the ship

Port-day rhythms in the Caribbean are well-established but vigilance matters. The detail in this subsection is deliberate; the consequences of getting it wrong are real.

Choosing a taxi. At Caribbean ports, licensed taxis are easy to identify — clear markings, government-issued ID badges visible, either a meter or a posted official rate sheet from the port authority. In the Bahamas (Freeport, Bimini), licensed taxis have set zone fares posted at the cruise terminal. In Progreso, Mexico, the licensed taxis at the pier-end terminal are union-regulated. Use only licensed drivers. If a driver tells you the meter is broken, walk to the next driver — common scam.

Currency at ports. USD is widely accepted in the Bahamas and Mexico. Small bills (\$5s, \$10s, \$20s) are most useful. Local currency change-back happens; if you receive Bahamian dollars (1:1 with USD) or Mexican pesos as change, you can use them for the rest of the day or keep them as souvenirs. Don't try to spend leftover Mexican pesos back in the U.S. — exchange fees eat the value.

Pickpocketing and personal awareness. Pickpocketing is not endemic at any of these ports but it does happen. Don't pull out a phone at the pier or near tour-vendor crowds. Keep your phone in a hard-to-reach pocket; passport and main money in a hotel-style internal money belt or zipped inside-jacket pocket. A small day-pack worn on the front (not the back) on busy promenades is sensible. None of this is fear-mongering — it's the same advice you'd take walking through a tourist district in Rome or Bangkok.

Common scams to be aware of (not to fear). They mostly involve pressure-selling: pier-side “free” guided walks that turn into shop-stop tours, fake “official” tour vendors wearing matching shirts claiming to represent the cruise line, “watch your bag” scams, counterfeit goods sold as authentic. None escalate beyond financial pressure. Politely decline, walk away, don't engage.

If you miss the ship at a port (the “all aboard” deadline). This happens more often than cruise lines admit. The cruise line's “all aboard” time is typically 30 minutes before sailaway. If you're not back at the pier by all-aboard, the ship sails without you. Here's the actual protocol:

1. **First, call the ship's port agent immediately.** The contact information is in the Voyages app.
2. **The port agent will advise on next steps.** Typically: catch up to the ship at the next port. For this itinerary, the next stop after Freeport is Progreso (you'd need to fly Nassau → Mérida); after Progreso, the next stop is Bimini (fly Mérida → Miami → seaplane or charter); after Bimini, you simply wait for return to PortMiami.
3. **You are responsible for the catch-up cost.** Flights from Caribbean ports run \$300–800. A hotel night in the missed port runs \$100–250. Total: typically \$400–1,000 plus meals and ground transport.
4. **Travel insurance with “trip interruption” coverage reimburses this** if you have it.
5. **Bring your passport in port, not in your cabin safe.** This is the strongest argument for actual passport over passport card.
6. **Time zones — read the Voyages app before each port.** Resilient Lady keeps “ship time” — usually U.S. Eastern Time on a Caribbean run from PortMiami. Notes that surprise people: Bahamas observes Eastern Time with daylight saving, matching the U.S. East Coast year-round in February (both EST). **Mexico's Yucatán observes Central Standard Time year-round** — so during EST months

(your February sailing) Progreso's local clock is **one hour behind ship time**. The only clock that matters for re-boarding is ship time.

If your situation is more serious than “missed the ship” — illness in port that requires hospitalization, lost passport with no way to fly, criminal incident — the U.S. Embassy or Consulate in each country handles emergency assistance. See **Section 6 — Emergency Contacts** for the full contact list and the family handoff card.

Special diets, allergies, and religious dietary needs

Notify Virgin Voyages at booking AND have Tina confirm the request was logged in your reservation. Virgin's kitchens are well set up to accommodate a wide range of dietary needs.

Severe food allergies (peanut, tree-nut, shellfish, egg, dairy, soy). Virgin takes severe allergies seriously. At booking, log the allergy in your reservation. At check-in, mention it again. At each restaurant, mention it to your server when seated — they'll bring the chef out if needed. If your allergy is anaphylactic-grade, bring two epinephrine auto-injectors regardless; the ship's medical center has them but not always quickly accessible.

Celiac disease and gluten sensitivity. Virgin handles gluten-free well. Pink Agave's full menu is gluten-free; The Galley has gluten-free stations; main restaurants (The Wake, Extra Virgin, Razzle Dazzle, Gunbae, Test Kitchen) all have gluten-free options. Cross-contamination risk is lower than legacy-line buffets because there's no buffet — every meal is plated.

Vegan and vegetarian. Razzle Dazzle is Virgin's vegetable-forward restaurant (the menu reads as both vegan-friendly and omnivore-friendly without judgment in either direction). Pink Agave has multiple vegan options. Extra Virgin will adapt pasta dishes on request. The Galley has dedicated vegan and vegetarian stations. No advance notice needed for vegan/vegetarian; ask at the meal.

Kosher and halal observance. Virgin Voyages' kosher and halal options are limited compared to dedicated charter sailings. Some pre-packaged frozen kosher meals may be available on request — confirm at booking via Tina, well in advance, not at the day of. For halal, the same protocol applies. If full kosher or halal observance is essential, a sailing specifically marketed as observant may be a better fit than this group cruise.

Diabetic and low-sugar dietary management. Both restaurant menus and The Galley have options for diabetic management. Tell your server on Day 1 if you want flagged options on the menu. Insulin storage in the cabin requires a refrigerated location — most Virgin cabins have a small fridge; if yours doesn't, ask your stateroom host to provide a small medical fridge (free).

Laundry on board

Virgin Voyages does not have self-service laundry on Lady Class ships.

Full-service laundry. Submit a bag at your cabin; turnaround is typically 24 hours. Pricing is per-item. Specifics vary by sailing — confirm rates in the Voyages app or the in-cabin price card.

Pressing service. If you packed a wrinkled outfit for Scarlet Night or for The Wake, pressing-only service is available for a per-item fee, 12–24 hour turnaround.

Travel hack. If a formal item is just lightly wrinkled, hang it in the cabin bathroom and run a hot shower for 5 minutes with the bathroom door closed. The steam relaxes most light wrinkles.

Lost items and lost-and-found

Onboard:

- **Visit the Sailor Services desk** (Deck 5). They have a centralized lost-and-found.
- **End-of-cruise reconciliation.** If you notice something missing on Day 6 or Day 7, deal with it at Sailor Services *before* disembarkation. Items left in cabins after disembarkation enter the lost-and-found queue but matching is much harder.
- **High-value items (jewelry, cash, electronics).** Ship security has CCTV throughout common areas. Most “lost” valuables are misplacement; theft does occur but is rare on cruise ships.
- **The cabin safe.** Use it. Keys, wallets, passports when in port (carry the passport with you; keep the rest in the safe).

In port:

- **Items lost in port** are reported to local police, not to the ship. Each port has tourist-information offices that can direct you. Get a written police report — your travel insurance will require it for any claim.
- **Lost passport in port.** The U.S. Embassy or Consulate in each country issues emergency travel documents, but the process takes 24–72 hours minimum. The ship's port agent will advise on hotel and transportation. If the missed-ship contingency happens because of a lost passport, your travel insurance's trip-interruption coverage applies.

Photography and privacy onboard

Modern cruise ships are highly photographed environments — by the cruise line, by other passengers, by you. Virgin Voyages has fewer ship photographers than legacy lines (Virgin's brand language doesn't lean on "embarkation photo packages" the way NCL and Royal do), but a few practical considerations apply:

Social media at sea. Wi-Fi on Resilient Lady is metered or capped depending on your tier. Live-streaming, large photo uploads, and video calls all consume bandwidth heavily. Save those for port-day cellular or for after the cruise.

The Manor and the Red Room. The Manor's dance floor and the Red Room's productions both have low light and active stage lighting; phone photos rarely capture them well, and flash is disruptive to performers and other guests. Most sailors find the experience is better when phones stay in pockets.

Cabin privacy. The *do not disturb* sign on the cabin door is respected by stateroom hosts. The cabin attendant will skip your cabin entirely on do-not-disturb days; don't expect turn-down service or fresh towels until you remove the sign.

A note for grieving travelers and women in transition. Some Sisters on this cruise will be processing a recent loss or transition — divorce, widowhood, a hard year. Photos and social media can intensify difficult emotions in unpredictable ways. There is no obligation to participate in the visual record of the trip. The Sun Club Café in late afternoon and the Red Room before the evening show are particularly camera-light environments; they're where you go when you don't want to be in someone else's photo.

Faith resources at sea

Virgin Voyages is a secular cruise line and does not run scheduled religious services in the way some legacy lines do. There is no Sunday morning interfaith service on the Voyages app schedule by default; there is no chaplain rotation.

For personal observance: the Sun Club Café area (top deck forward) is the most peaceful space on the ship — sunrise prayer at sea is a real experience. Outdoor decks at sunrise and sunset are reliably quiet. Your cabin is private.

A note about pastoral content. The site that produced this pack has explicit faith-aware content elsewhere — the **/solo/** section addresses cruising in grief, the meaning of moving water, and the way solo travel can become spiritual practice. Several articles by Tina (**Why I Started Solo Cruising**) are gently faith-aware. We don't promote that content into this pack because the buyer audience is broader than the faith audience, but it's there for those who want to find it.

Post-cruise: refunds, disputes, and the cruise blues

The cruise doesn't quite end at disembarkation. Two practical post-cruise topics matter.

Refunds and billing disputes. The end-of-cruise statement that arrives Day 8 morning is the official record. Disputes are easier handled at Sailor Services on the ship Day 7 evening or Day 8 early morning than after disembarkation. Common dispute categories: wrong charge applied, shore excursion that didn't deliver as promised, booking-level disputes. **Tina is the right channel for booking-level disputes** — she handles the cruise-line-side conversation on your behalf as your booking agent.

Post-cruise blues. The cruise blues are real — cruise psychologists have written about them, regular cruisers experience them, and the pattern is predictable. After a week of structured rhythm, sun, saltwater, group warmth, and the absence of ordinary-life decision-making, returning to email and laundry and traffic can feel hollow for several days. It's not a problem to solve; it's a transition to feel through.

What experienced cruisers report works:

- **Don't unpack the suitcase for two days.** Preserves the trip mentally; the smell of the cruise lasts a day or two and is part of the wind-down.

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- **Plan a debrief dinner with another Sister 2–3 weeks out.** The trip becomes a story you tell rather than an experience that ended.
 - **Don't book the next cruise immediately.** Some find this hopeful; others find it avoidant. If you're booking the next one to hold off the blues, sit with the blues for a week first.
 - **Stay in touch with anyone you connected with.** The friendships formed on a Sisters at Sea cruise are real if you maintain them. Tina facilitates an email exchange at the farewell event; use it.
 - **Notice what the trip taught you about your daily life.** A week of sleep, sun, and slow meals often surfaces the parts of your ordinary routine that feel off. The cruise itself didn't cause those changes — but the rhythm of the cruise gave them room to surface.
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Section 9 — The Group Cruise Rhythm

A hosted group cruise is a different experience from a regular cruise on the same ship. The differences are mostly small but they shape the week.

What “hosted” actually means

Tina, as group host, has organized the booking, will run several scheduled meetups during the sailing, will be available as a coordinator for shared concerns, and is the bridge between the Sisters and Virgin's own group services. She is **not** going to lead every activity, choreograph every dinner, or be on call 24/7. She's a facilitator, not a tour guide. The week's character emerges from the group itself.

What you can typically expect from a Sisters at Sea sailing:

- **A welcome packet** in your cabin on Day 1 with the week's schedule
- **A welcome reception or meet-and-greet** on Day 1 evening or Day 2 afternoon
- **One or two group dinners** during the week (often at one of Virgin's signature restaurants — Pink Agave or Extra Virgin work well for groups)

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- **At least one group activity** — could be a hosted port-day excursion, a Beach Club gathering, or an onboard event like Drag Brunch
 - **A farewell event** the night before disembarkation
 - **A Valentine's-themed welcome** on Day 1 — pink and red touches, a toast, the framing of “come solo, leave with sisters”

What you should NOT expect:

- That the group will eat together every night (Virgin's no-fixed-seating model makes this impractical even for dedicated groups)
- That you'll have a structured itinerary every hour
- That solo time is discouraged — quite the opposite, Tina's whole approach is about respecting solo space within group warmth

Why groups work well for solo women

Hosted solo-women groups solve the central challenge of solo cruising: the structural awkwardness of dining alone every night, finding people for excursions, navigating the social-by-default expectation of cruise activities. With a group, the default is friendly familiarity. You walk into Pink Agave at 7 PM and several tables wave you over.

This doesn't mean you have to socialize all the time. The Sun Club Café and Richard's Rooftop (suite-only, but the upper open decks generally) are still there for quiet hours. But the *option* of group warmth is built in.

The Valentine's framing matters. Solo cruises around Valentine's Day can feel weighted — for women navigating recent losses, recent divorces, kids leaving home, or a long stretch of singlehood that wasn't planned. Tina chose this date deliberately. The group culture turns the Valentine's-couple-default on its head: you're not the third wheel, you're the center of the trip. The gentle tone of the welcome, the way the group's rhythm acknowledges what brought each Sister there — all of this is intentional.

How to make the group experience work for you

A few patterns that solo cruisers in hosted groups have reported as useful:

- **Accept the first invitation.** On Day 1 or Day 2, when someone in the group invites you to dinner or a show, say yes. The first connection is the hardest; afterward, the rhythm finds itself.
- **Pick one regular spot.** A morning coffee location (Grounds Club at 8 AM, or The Galley's coffee station), a sunset deck location (the upper aft pool deck). Other Sisters will find you naturally; you become a fixture.
- **Don't try to know everyone.** A group of 20–60 will produce 3–8 real connections and dozens of friendly nodding acquaintances. That's normal.
- **Use Tina as a resource, not as a tour guide.** If something is unclear or you need help connecting with another Sister, ask her. If you're trying to manage every detail, that's not what she signed up for.

Cabin-block configuration

Tina has likely reserved a block of cabins for the group, often in the same general area of the ship. Sister cabins near each other means easy gathering, easy door-knock invites, and easy “let's all go to dinner” coordination. **Confirm the block configuration with Tina** — what categories are still available, which decks the block is on, whether there are connecting cabins for Sisters traveling as pairs.

A note on group politics

Any group of solo women has political diversity, life-stage diversity, and class diversity. A Sisters at Sea cruise has — almost universally — an unstated agreement to leave that diversity at the gangway. The week works because everyone knows the deal. If you're someone who thrives on political conversation, you'll find people for it discreetly. If you're someone who came to escape it, the group culture will protect you.

Section 10 — Solo Female Considerations

This section is for solo women cruisers planning a February 2027 cruise. Some of the content applies to all solo cruisers; some is specific to women traveling alone.

Why Virgin Voyages fits a solo woman well

Several structural reasons:

- **Adults-only by design.** The buffet that's normally the loud center of a mass-market ship doesn't exist on Resilient Lady. There is no kid energy at the pool, no family chaos in the dining room, no waterslide noise. The whole demographic shape of the ship is different.
- **20+ included restaurants make eating alone feel normal.** No assigned dinner table for eight. You can walk into Pink Agave alone with a book at 6 PM and feel completely at home; you can also share a Gunbae round table with five Sisters and stay for hours. The flexibility is the point.
- **The demographic on Virgin skews younger and more diverse than legacy lines.** Average age on a Virgin sailing tends to be 35–55 (vs. 55–70 on a typical NCL or Royal Caribbean Caribbean run). More women travel solo on Virgin specifically *because* of this demographic shift; you will not be the only woman traveling alone in the dining room.
- **No formal nights, no traditional cruise conventions.** Smart casual evenings; Scarlet Night as the only “themed” night and red is the only requirement. Less pressure, more room to be yourself.
- **Bar Tab over drink package.** The drink-package math on legacy lines often makes solo cruisers feel like they're paying for something they don't use; Virgin's pay-as-you-go Bar Tab fits a moderate drinker better.

Solo female safety

Solo cruising is overwhelmingly safe — cruise ships are among the most surveilled travel environments on earth, with CCTV throughout common areas, a 24-hour security presence, controlled access to passenger decks, and crew trained in emergency response. The Cruise Vessel Security and Safety Act (federal U.S. law since 2010)

mandates specific safety protocols including security camera coverage, the trained Sexual Assault Response Team that every U.S.-departing cruise ship carries, and reporting obligations. None of this means risk is zero, but the baseline is high.

That said, a few habits make sense:

Your cabin door. The standard Virgin cabin door has both a deadbolt and a privacy latch (a small swing-arm that prevents the door from opening even with a master key). Use both at night. The deadbolt is the primary security feature; the privacy latch adds a second physical barrier and prevents the stateroom host from entering during turn-down service if you're inside. Some solo cruisers add a **portable doorstop or door wedge** under the door at night — cheap (under \$10), takes no space. For travelers who experience anxiety in unfamiliar sleeping environments, the wedge is calming.

Share your itinerary before sailing. Send a copy of the day-by-day to one trusted person ashore — adult child, sibling, close friend. Include the ship name (Resilient Lady), your cabin number once assigned, your travel insurance policy number, and Tina's contact. Share the **U.S. State Department's Overseas Citizens Services line** as the right call for any true at-sea emergency: **+1-888-407-4747** (from U.S./Canada) or **+1-202-501-4444** (from abroad), 24 hours a day, every day. The State Department can locate the ship, contact Virgin Voyages through official channels, and coordinate consular services if needed — at no cost to your family. This isn't paranoia; it's the same hand-off you'd give if you were going on any extended solo trip.

Photo copies of essential documents. Before sailing, photograph or scan: passport ID page, driver's license, all credit cards (front and back), travel insurance card, medication list with prescribing doctors. Email these to yourself and to your trusted contact ashore. Keep the originals in your cabin safe; carry only what you need to the port.

Port-day boundaries. A friendly conversation at trivia is not an invitation to dinner. A friendly dinner is not an invitation to a port-day. A port-day is not an invitation to anything else. You set the pace; “no thanks, I'm enjoying the quiet today” is always available, and on a Sisters at Sea cruise specifically, declining isn't going to fracture the group — every solo cruiser there has had moments of needing alone-time.

Boundaries with romantic interest. Solo cruises are sometimes described as singles cruises or hookup environments. Sisters at Sea is *not* that. Tina screens her group toward women who are seeking community, not dating. That said, romantic chemistry

can happen on cruises (between Sisters, between sailors and other-group sailors, occasionally with crew — though crew-passenger relationships are tightly regulated by Virgin). The framework solo women report works: be willing to share a meal with a fellow sailor; not willing to share your cabin number; willing to exchange contact information after the cruise; not willing to invite anyone into your cabin during the cruise. You don't owe an explanation; the framework is the explanation.

If something feels off. Resilient Lady has 24-hour security presence. Sailor Services on Deck 5 is the front door for any concern — they respond fast. If a fellow sailor is being intrusive, if a crew member is overstepping, if you feel followed in a corridor, security can intervene. Most solo cruisers go a lifetime without needing to use security; the option exists if you do. Sailor Services can also reassign your cabin if your assigned cabin neighbor is the source of a problem (extremely rare, but the protocol exists).

In port, walk with another Sister when possible. This is one of the underrated benefits of a hosted group cruise — you naturally have travel companions for port days. Tour vendors and pickpockets target solo travelers more than pairs or groups. If you can't find a partner for the day, stay in well-trafficked tourist areas, especially in Progreso (where the language gap can feel disorienting on first arrival). Tell Tina or the group what your day plan is.

The “Sisters at Sea” social rhythm

The Valentine's framing of this cruise — *come solo, leave with sisters* — is the design principle. Tina runs hosted events with the deliberate intention of generating the conditions for friendship without forcing it. The Day 1 welcome reception, the Day 2 meet-and-greet, the mid-week group dinner, the farewell — each is structured to lower the activation energy for connection.

You can opt in or opt out at any moment. The hosted events are voluntary. If you went to the welcome reception and the meet-and-greet but you're tired by Day 4 and want to read on your balcony for the day, that's a complete sentence. Other Sisters will respect it. Tina won't take it personally.

The friendships are real if you tend them. Sisters at Sea participants who report the most lasting connections are the ones who:

- Said yes to the first invitation

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- Exchanged contact info before disembarkation
 - Followed up within two weeks of getting home
 - Made plans to meet for coffee or a weekend within six months

Sisters who reported the trip as “a nice cruise but the friendships didn’t stick” are the ones who let contacts go cold within a month. Tina facilitates the email exchange; the maintenance is yours.

For solo women carrying loss or transition

Some Sisters on this cruise will be processing recent loss — a spouse who died, a marriage that ended, a parent in late illness, kids who just left for college, a career chapter that closed. The Valentine’s date is deliberately loaded: it’s the holiday that magnifies loneliness for women in the middle of those transitions.

The trip will not fix what brought you to it. That’s not what cruises do. What this trip can do — at its best — is offer a week of structure, sun, slow meals, ocean motion, and other women who get it. Predictable schedule. No hard decisions. The rhythm of the ship doing the navigating while you do the resting.

Practical pastoral notes (no advertising, no urgency):

- The Sun Club Café in late afternoon is the gentlest space on the ship for the kind of reflection that grief and transition require.
- **Tina’s article on cruising in the wake of grief** — when published — will be the gentlest version of this conversation we have. Her **Why I Started Solo Cruising** is already there and worth reading before you sail.
- The group will not interrogate. Stories are shared by invitation, not by interrogation. If you want to talk about why you came, someone will listen; if you don’t, no one will press.
- Several Sisters will be in similar situations. You won’t be the only one. You won’t be visibly sad in a sea of cheerful couples — there are no couples here, and the demographic is calibrated for exactly your kind of trip.

If you’re in active acute grief (the first 6–12 weeks after a major loss), a cruise may be too much structure. If you’re 6+ months into the integration of a loss, a cruise can be exactly right. Trust your own read.

Section 11 — Solo Cruising Deep-Dive

This section is for solo cruisers more generally. Some content overlaps with Section 10 (Solo Female Considerations); the focus here is the practical playbook rather than the social-emotional framing.

The cabin question — solo specifics

Virgin Voyages does not offer a dedicated solo cabin the way NCL does (the Studio model). Instead, **single occupancy of a regular cabin** is how solo cruising works on Virgin — with a single supplement that varies by sailing.

For this Sisters at Sea group, **Tina has negotiated solo pricing directly into the flyer rates** (\$2,009 Insider, \$2,508 Sea View, \$2,652 Sea Terrace). That's a structural difference from a normal Virgin booking — you're not paying a 175–200% single supplement. You're paying a per-person rate that's been pre-negotiated for this group.

If the flyer rates feel high relative to a NCL Studio (\$1,799 from a comparable group flyer), remember:

- Virgin's fare *includes* basic Wi-Fi (~\$120 saved vs. legacy lines)
- Virgin's fare *includes* all dining, including specialty (\$150–300 saved)
- Virgin's gratuity is either bundled (Legacy Fare) or unbundled at \$140–154 (post-Oct-2025 fare) — vs. ~\$140 auto-gratuity on NCL/Royal, so close to even
- Virgin's cabins are larger and 86% have balconies

The all-in math typically lands close to even by the door.

Where to find people on Resilient Lady

- **Hosted group events** — Tina's gatherings are designed for solo connection; show up
- **The Galley's communal coffee station** in the morning — a friendly low-stakes morning crowd
- **Grounds Club** for specialty coffee — a seated, talkative space

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- **Pink Agave's bar seating** — solo-friendly, with the bartender often making conversation
 - **The Manor's earlier hours** (before 11 PM) — the dance floor opens up for friendly social dancing rather than the late-night party
 - **Group fitness classes** — friendly demographics, low conversation barrier
 - **Trivia at the bars** — typically afternoons on sea days, the friendliest organized social activity

What to expect

Solo cruising on Resilient Lady is good for the same reason group cruising on Resilient Lady is good: the ship is large enough that you have privacy when you want it and crowds when you want them. The risk is that the daily structure of cruise life can feel either liberating or lonely without a partner. Build rituals: the same morning coffee spot, the same trivia hour, the same sunset deck.

For Tina's complete thinking on solo cruising — *what works, what doesn't, what surprises first-time solo cruisers* — see her **solo articles hub**. Her **Why I Started Solo Cruising** is the origin story; more articles are in development.

A small joy: cruise ducks

There's a tradition on cruise ships of bringing small rubber ducks and hiding them around the ship for fellow passengers to find. Solo women cruisers often find this cheerfully ridiculous — which is the point. If you want to participate, see **the cruise duck tradition article**. The site that produced this pack also runs a **Duck Club affinity tier** of supporters who find the tradition meaningful. (No pressure to join; just mentioned because it's of-a-piece with the spirit of group cruising.)

Continue planning on the site

A few threads worth pulling on the rest of the site between now and February 2027.

About your ship

- **Video walkthroughs of Resilient Lady** — short clips of public spaces and deck areas, gathered on her **video highlights section**.
- **Logbook entries from other travelers** — first-hand notes from sailors aboard, on the **Resilient Lady logbook section** of her ship page.
- **Deck plans and the first-look gallery** for orientation before you board: **first look** and **deck plans**.

About the ports

Each port has its own page on the site, with restaurant pointers, walking-distance notes, and traveler observations:

- **Freeport (Grand Bahama) port page**
- **Progreso port page** (gateway to Mérida and Chichén Itzá)
- **The Beach Club at Bimini port page**

About Tina and her solo work

- **Tina Maulsby's author page** — her bio, her hosting style, and the way she runs a group.
- **Tina's solo articles hub** — the broader writing on solo cruising that frames this trip.

Other Voyage Packs

The **full Voyage Packs catalog** lists every itinerary we've packed — useful if a future trip is on your mind alongside this one.

Closing

This pack exists to make one specific cruise easier. It's calmer than most planning content, by design, because the audience deserves that calm.

The cruise itself is a real opportunity: a hosted group of solo women, on Virgin Voyages' adult-by-design Resilient Lady, sailing one of the more interesting itineraries the Caribbean has to offer (Freeport, Progreso's Mayan world, the Beach Club at Bimini Virgin designed and operates on its port days), hosted by someone who knows solo travel firsthand. The Valentine's framing — *come solo, leave with sisters* — is a specific kind of trip that doesn't exist elsewhere on the legacy lines.

What I'd want a friend to know, if she were preparing:

- **Trust Tina.** She has a solo cruiser's instinct and a hosted-group's discipline. She will not over-program and she will not under-prepare.
- **Pack the medication buffer.** The single most-recommended action in this pack.
- **Say yes to the first dinner invitation.** It compounds.
- **Bring something red for Scarlet Night.** Even if you'd never wear red at home — pack one item.
- **The Sea Terrace upgrade is small money for the difference it makes.** \$144 above Sea View, at the flyer rate.
- **Don't try to do everything.** Resilient Lady is comfortable enough that "doing nothing" on a sea day is a valid use of the day.
- **The Beach Club at Bimini deserves its full day.** Don't book a complicated excursion; the beach itself is the experience.
- **Take photos of Sisters, not just of yourself.** The friendships are the souvenir worth keeping.

If this pack helped

If this pack made the trip easier and you'd like to support the site, you can **buy us a coffee**. The site stays free of advertising because of supporters like you. There's no pressure — the **support page** lists other ways too, including the Duck Club. The booking itself runs through Tina, separately, and is already paying her travel agency the way travel agencies are paid.

A note about post-cruise

Post-cruise blues are real. Sit with them for a week before booking the next trip. Stay in touch with the Sisters you connected with. Consider what the trip taught you about your daily life — the rhythm of slow meals and quiet water often surfaces things worth noticing.

Share or save. The HTML version of this pack has a floating share bar (lower-right on desktop) — copy a link, ping a Sister on WhatsApp, or generate a QR code if you're showing the page to someone in person. If the trip becomes the start of a solo-women cruising community for you, an Instagram or X post tagged with the cruise line and Tina's handle (@maulsbytravel — confirm with her before posting) helps the next solo cruiser find groups like Sisters at Sea.

If this Voyage Pack is the right shape for your trip but the wrong itinerary, **more Voyage Packs** cover other lines and routes. The site's editorial **audit log** shows how content here gets reviewed if you want to see the trail.

Soli Deo Gloria. Have a good week at sea.

About this document

Voyage Pack version	v0.1.3 prototype
Prepared for	Internal review (not yet for sale)
Itinerary	Sisters at Sea — A Valentine's Getaway for Solo Cruisers Who Love to Cruise — Resilient Lady, PortMiami, Feb 14–21, 2027
Group host	Tina Maulsby, Maulsby Travel Co.

Sources	Resilient Lady, Freeport, Progreso, Bimini, Tina Maulsby , Virgin Voyages Security Guide PDF , accessibility-at-sea , /internet-at-sea.html , /drink-calculator.html , /articles/cruise-cabin-organization.html , /articles/cruise-tech-photography-guide.html , /packing-lists.html , /first-cruise.html , /countdown.html , assets/data/ship-deployments.json
Last reviewed	2026-06-05
Pricing reminder	All prices in this document are approximate. Confirm with Tina at tina@maulsbytravel.com / 910-528-5077, or in the Voyages app once you've booked
Cross-link audit	25+ internal links to existing site content, demonstrating the pack as a curated entry-point into the broader In the Wake authority surface
Virgin contact verification	Verified Virgin Voyages does not appear to publish a public ship-to-shore phone number on its primary website. Family-emergency contact directs to U.S. State Department line per Virgin's own Security Guide. Sailor Services email confirmed; phone numbers from third-party directories are NOT included to avoid wrong-number risk in an emergency
Funding model	This site is independent. See /affiliate-disclosure.html and /support.html for details. The pack is a one-time purchase; cruise booking is handled separately by Maulsby Travel Co.